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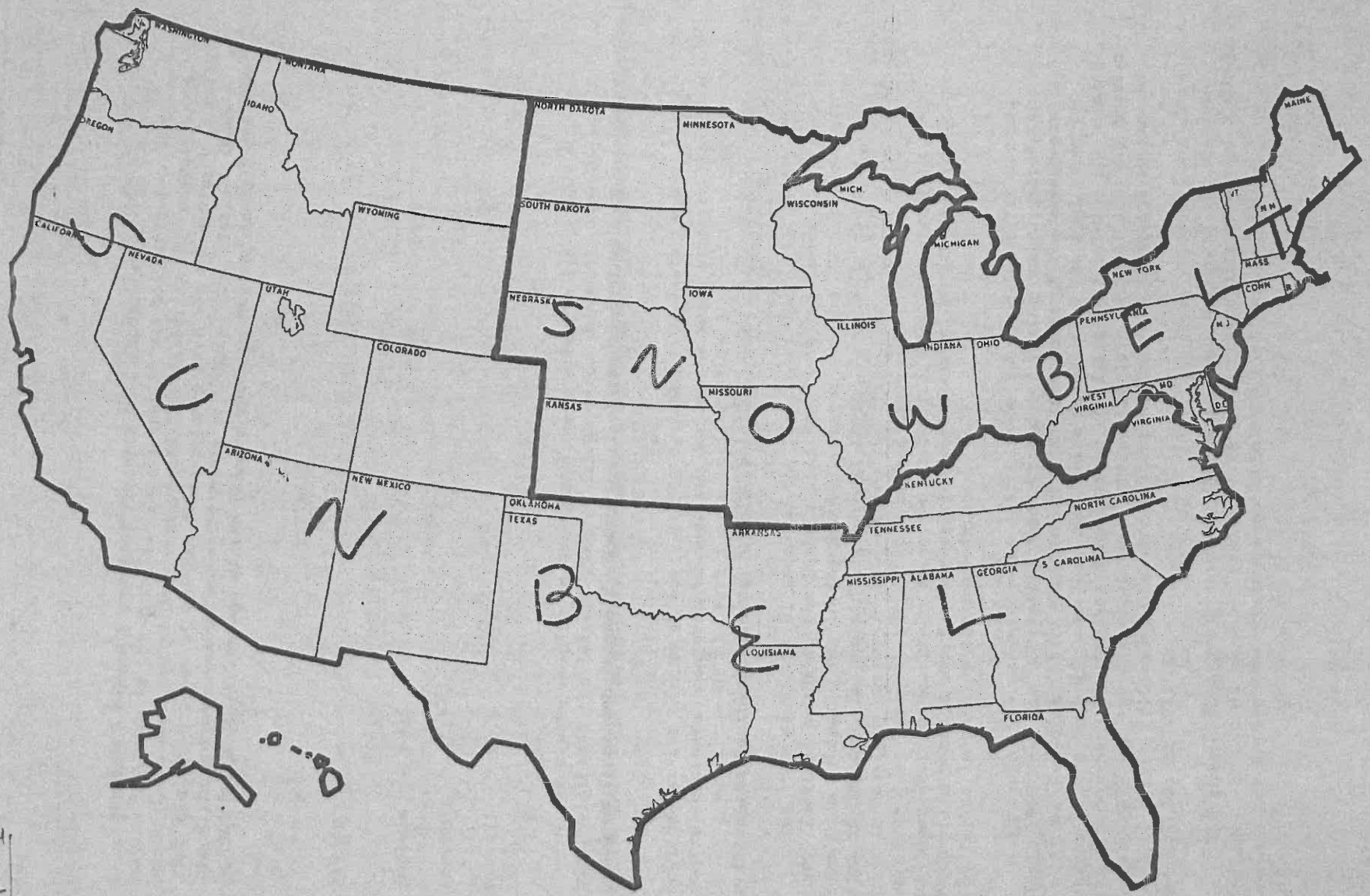
SUNBELT AND SNOWBELT



map 1

President Reagan's greatest strength as a candidate for the GOP nomination has been in the Sunbelt. Recall that it was his victory in the March North Carolina primary that revived his faltering 1976 campaign, and that his 100-0 sweep of the May Texas primary gave him the strength to carry his fight for the nomination all the way to Kansas City. Table 1 shows Ronald Reagan's percentage of the primary vote, by region, in 1976 and 1980.

TABLE 1

Region	1976		1980	
	Reagan	Others	Reagan	Others
Sunbelt	59.6	40.4	71.6	28.4
Snowbelt	36.7	63.3	54.3	45.7
Overall	45.9	54.1	63.0	37.0

It is always helpful to know where one's strength lies. In 1984, the South will send the largest bloc of delegates to the Dallas convention, based on President Reagan's victory in 12 of the 13 Southern states in 1980.

The GOP presidential orientation toward the Sunbelt since 1960 has been rewarded at the electoral college. We have won three of the last six presidential contests, compared to just two out of the seven prior to that. And we have won three of the last four elections since 1968, when Richard Nixon refined the Southern Strategy to high political art.

The 1964 presidential race was the first ever where the GOP nominee got more electoral votes in the Sunbelt than he did in the Snowbelt. At the same time Goldwater was losing Snowbelt states for the GOP for the first time in decades, he was winning Sunbelt states for the GOP for the first time in nearly a century. 1964 marked the first time that the Republicans had ever lost Vermont, but it also marked the first time that the Republicans had ever carried Georgia. These two states had never deviated from their respective parties since those parties were founded, but in 1964 tradition was felled in both on the same date.

Although 1964 presaged many shifts in national politics, it was not until 1968 that the GOP really demonstrated its rising Sunbelt strength. In that year Democrat Hubert Humphrey carried just three of the twenty-six states in the Sunbelt, and just one in the South. But the real power of the GOP Southern Strategy is displayed by the difference between the popular vote totals and the electoral vote totals. In 1968 Humphrey lost the popular vote by a mere 7/10ths of one percent, but he lost the electoral college by a hefty 303 to 191.

The reason for this divergence is the peculiar nature of the electoral college. It awards the same number of votes to the popular winner of a state, whether he carries that state by one vote or a million.

1964 Goldwater was blown away in the Outer South. But he carried the Deep South! For three of these states, 1964 represented the first time they had gone Republican since Reconstruction, and for a fourth--Georgia--it was the first time ever.

In percentage terms, Goldwater got 62.0% of the vote in the Deep South but just 42.4% of the Outer South vote. That spread of 19.6 percentage points is a high for the whole 1948-1968 era of the fragmented South, and symbolizes the political impotence of the region in this period.

Lest anyone doubt that racially inspired voting was still the key to Southern elections, the figures in Table 10 should dispel those doubts. They show that the five best Dixiecrat states were also Goldwater's five best states (not just in the South, but nationwide):

TABLE 10

	1948 Dixiecrat %	1964 Goldwater %
Mississippi	87.2	87.1
Alabama	79.7	69.5
South Carolina	72.0	58.9
Louisiana	49.1	56.8
Georgia	20.3	54.1

In 1968 the South again divided its electoral votes, between Nixon, who carried seven states, Wallace who carried five, and Humphrey, who won only LBJ's Texas. Nixon not only carried the majority of Southern states, but he won the lion's share of the South's electoral college vote. For the Democrats, 1968 was their worst showing--so far--in Dixie.

5. The New Solid South

a. 1972: The McGovern Catalyst

George McGovern was never destined to be President. Nixon was on a roll in 1971-72, with the trip to China, the SALT agreement, a booming economy, and an impending settlement in Vietnam. He could probably have beaten any Democrat in 1972. But McGovern was not just any Democrat. He was undoubtedly the most liberal man ever nominated for the presidency by a major party. He won the nomination thanks to the wizardry of his campaign manager's manipulation of the rules, which for example led to the expulsion of the regular Chicago and South Carolina delegations and their replacement by handpicked cadres of McGovernites.

McGovern of South Dakota was never expected to do well in the South--and he didn't. Few realized at the time, however, that McGovern's candidacy would be the catalyst for the reunification of the South. McGovern, candidate of acid, abortion, and amnesty, was a man the South could easily unite against. And it did. McGovern not only lost all thirteen states--reuniting the region for the first time since 1944--but he failed to get more than 34% of the vote in any Southern state!

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There were other reasons why the South was so unanimous. By 1972 the storm over civil rights had subsided. By no means was the race problem in the South solved by the early 1970's, but then that was true of the rest of the country as well. The renewed harmony between Outer and Deep South as indicated by the South's electoral college unanimity, is even more effectively demonstrated in Table 11, which shows the respective Republican percentages of the Outer and Deep South from 1964 to 1972.

TABLE 11

Republican Percentage of the Vote

	Deep South	Outer South	Percentage Spread
1964	62.0	42.4	19.6
1968	23.9	40.6	16.7
1972	72.0	68.6	3.4

The 1972 election results demonstrated plainly that the Democratic presidential strategy was completely bankrupt. A succession of Northern liberals had converted the Solid Democratic South into a Solid Republican South in just twenty-eight years. Graph 4 shows how dramatic this plunge was.

b. The Rise of the Southern GOP

Coincident with the fragmentation of the Solid Democratic South was the rise of the Southern GOP. Table 12 shows the party of Lincoln as it stood in the South in 1948 and then in 1972:

TABLE 12

	1948	1972
Southern Republican Senators	1	10
Southern Republican Governors	0	3
Southern Republican Congressmen	6	38

But even though the general Republican trend was upward in the South in the decades following 1948, the Deep South and Outer South behaved much differently. In 1964, for example, the GOP gained seven House seats in the Deep South--the first such wins since Reconstruction--even as three Republican incumbent Congressmen were defeated in the Outer South. In 1966 Deep South Republicanism had subsided, and the GOP lost one net seat in that area, even as they won eleven new House seats in the Outer South.

But by 1972 the Outer and Inner South were starting to move toward the GOP at about the same speed. In that year the Republicans won four new House seats in the Outer South, and three more in the Deep South.

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vote much, because the Bourbons threw roadblocks (i.e. literacy tests and poll taxes) in their way, and because the general election results were a foregone conclusion. (Why pay to vote when the election is already decided?)

The big explosion in populist voter turnout occurred in 1964 and the years thereafter. The social engineering features of the Great Society were so offensive to the populists that they rushed to the polls to vote against Lyndon Johnson, Hubert Humphrey, George McGovern--and any other liberal on the ballot.

This anti-liberalism did not help the GOP much in state and local elections, since the Democrats running in those races generally shared the populists' views. Thus GOPers couldn't get much political running room.

However, the GOP did go from two Senate seats in 1960 to twelve seats in 1982 and from nine House seats to thirty-eight in that same period. So great progress was made in spite of our handicaps.

In all of these elections, the Republican formula for victory was to combine populist votes of the populists with country club votes to reach a majority.

In 1976 Jimmy Carter brought the Southern populists back into the Democratic camp after three straight Democratic losses. But in 1980 Carter lost them to Reagan and the GOP. Then the populist pendulum swung back in 1982, however, leaving the GOP with little besides the country-club base in elections from North Carolina to Mississippi.

b. Ideology

It is critical to our future success in the South that we understand the reasons for our inroads into the populist vote. As their name implies, populists are not laissez-faire free-marketers--they are not "laid back," not swayed by calm appeals to logic and reason.

Populists believe in activism. They believe the government should solve their problems for them. They believe in candidates who promise to shake up the establishment--leaders who promise bold, decisive action.

This profile fits the Democratic mold. To appeal to the Southern populists, we Republicans must come to grips with the deeply embedded ideology that has created many generations of these "yellow-dog" Democrats.

Populists have always been liberal on economics. So long as the crucial issues were generally confined to economics--as during the New Deal--the liberal candidate could expect to get most of the populist vote.

But populists are conservative on most social issues, including abortion, gun control and ERA. Also, populists usually lean conservative on foreign policy and national security issues. The South has always led the nation in volunteers in the military, particularly in the Vietnam War, giving rise to the joke about our troops being stationed in "South" Vietnam!

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Thus, when Republicans are successful in getting certain social issues to the forefront, the populist vote is lost to liberal causes and the Democrats. The trick we must master is choosing those social issues which do not alienate the country clubbers since, again, we need their votes and the populists' to win in the South.

For Southerners, the presidential elections of 1968 and 1972 were referendums on social issues and foreign policy. Such elections proved progressively better for the Republicans as we achieved our desired coalition of the country clubbers, populists and also those blacks who shared our principles.

The elections of 1976 and 1980 were a mix of these issues as we held the upper strate of white society, but fell short of a majority among the populists. In 1980 we were able to get enough of the populist vote to carry the South, but in most Southern states we still fell short of a majority. Recall that Ronald Reagan's regionwide percentage was just 51.3%.

The Democrats recaptured the populist vote in 1982, and Republicans were dealt defeat from Southwest Virginia to Southwest Texas.

After Carter's defeat the Democrats backed away from their Great Society rhetoric and diverted public attention from busing, affirmative action, etc. and toward clear economic issues, e.g. "fairness."

In 1982 we discovered we could not hold the populist vote on economic issues alone. When social and cultural issues died down, the populists were left with no compelling reason to vote Republican.

In 1981 Democrats built an alliance of blacks and populists to win their first statewide election in Virginia in sixteen years and recaptured a House seat in Jackson, Mississippi. In 1982 the Democrats continued this coalition, and won enough of the populist vote to carry areas with only small black populations, i.e. Western Virginia and North Carolina.

c. Wallace

The resurrection of George Wallace, arch-demagogue of the South for a generation, is illustrative of the Democrat's move from social and foreign policy issues to economic issues. Wallace built his reputation as the man who literally stood in the way of Southern desegregation. Capitalizing on this social issue, Wallace staked out a career as a five-term Alabama governor (including that of his late wife, Lurleen).

After milking the establishment's discomfiture over social and foreign policy difficulties for everything they were worth in the 1960's, Wallace began to emerge as a major political force and then as a presidential candidate in 1968.

His economic views were always in the shadow of his other themes, but a reading of his 1968 platform reveals a liberal economic streak amidst all the conservative and pseudo-conservative rhetoric about social and foreign policy.

elections stating that blacks loyally supported all white Democrats in the South, but that in the one major election (the 2nd District of Mississippi) involving a black Democrat, whites abandoned him for a white Republican.

Jackson has advocated a separate black party in the South, such as that present in 1978 in Mississippi when then-Representative Thad Cochran was elected Senator--the Magnolia State's first Republican to hold statewide office in this century.

A black third party would certainly damage the Democrats, but in my opinion it will be a long time before Southern blacks realize how the Democrats exploit them, and then break away. When they do, I predict they will join the GOP, not a third party.

4. The Fundamentals and the Republican Coalition, 1960-1982

Thus, we have as the main voting groups in Southern politics:

1. Country clubbers
2. Populists
3. Blacks

The first group--the former Bourbon Democrats who controlled the South by excluding groups two and three--are today reliably Republican. The third group--blacks--are reliably Democratic. In no state does either group have the numbers to assure a statewide victory.

Both groups must contend for the votes to the second group--the populists.

Actually, the populists are uneasy about alliances with either group. Their resentment of the wealth and status of the country clubbers offsets their historic antipathy for blacks.

The class struggle in the South continues, with the populists serving as the trump card in the game of politics. Table 33 presents in simplified form where the Southern populist vote went in the last six presidential elections, and also in 1982:

TABLE 33

	Republican	Democrat	Wallace
1960		x	
1964	x		
1968			x
1972	x		
1976		x	
1980	x		
1982		x	

Populists were still loyally Democratic in 1960 and were responsible for the election of John Kennedy. Such populist havens as Anderson and Spartanburg

On foreign policy, the South also demonstrates its populist bent with its extreme hawkishness, per a December 1982 Gallup poll shown in Table 38.

TABLE 38

Improve Relations with the USSR

	Favor	Oppose
West	79	15
Midwest	74	19
East	72	17
South	59	29

But on economics, the liberal side of Southern populism shines through, viz. Table 39:

TABLE 39

Percentage of Respondents Listing Unemployment as the Most Serious Problem

Midwest	58
South	45
East	44
West	36

The ranking by region in Table 39 may not seem that remarkable until the reader learns that of the four regions, the South has the lowest unemployment rate. Admittedly, Alabama has the third-highest rate in the nation, but it is far outweighed by Texas, whose unemployment rate is well below the national average. In November, the last month for which state-by-state breakdowns are available, the overall unemployment rate for the South was 9.5%, against 10.4% nationwide.

On question after question--from willingness to raise Social Security taxes to maintain current benefits, to guaranteeing each able-bodied American a job, to spending more on education and health care--the South rates as the most economically liberal region in the country.

3. The Image of the GOP

The Republicans, still regarded by many Southerners as the party of Wall Street, will have to work to keep the loyalty of Southerners who came to the GOP because of their disenchantment with Democratic foreign and social policies, not out of enthusiasm for supply side economics.

I certainly believe that an economic boom awaits the country in the 1980's, thanks to the tax and budget legislation of 1981-82. As the economy moves

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Since the Republican Party ably represents the white middle class, there is no reason why it shouldn't represent more of the black middle class; as America and the GOP continue to move toward the goal of a color-blind society.

In the South blacks comprise 20.7% of the population. They represent 20% or more of the population of 57 of the 129 Congressional districts in Dixie. Black voters broke records for turnout in 1982, and we must expect them to continue this trend in 1984. One of our key objectives for 1984 and beyond must be to garner a larger fraction of the black vote.

E. PARTY BUILDING

We should devote more attention to building up our various state GOP organizations in the South. To assure that our victory in 1984 extends to all levels, we need stronger grassroots activity, more broadly-based organizations, and pure and simply: more registered Republicans!

It is noteworthy that four of the five Senators the GOP elected in the South in 1980 were born elsewhere and moved South as adults (Denton is from Maryland, Hawkins is from Utah, and both East and Mattingly are from Illinois, only Nickles is from the state that elected him--Oklahoma).

Clearly many of the Republican parties around the South are still dominated by transplanted Northerners. There is nothing wrong with this--we need to run the best candidates we can find. But we will never truly be on an equal footing with the Democrats in the South until we develop credible, indigenous candidates.

F. PLAYING UP OUR MILITARY STRENGTH

As we saw in Table 38 in Section III, the South is our most hawkish region. Even as our national security policies are under attack in Washington, I can say with certainty that our defense buildup is popular in Dixie.

The military tradition runs deep in the South. Southerners have made more than their share of the collective national sacrifice to keep our nation free and strong. Southerners believe strongly in America and the flag and they don't care who knows it.

The South has innumerable defense installations, providing jobs and income from one end of the region to the other. The South is also heavy with military retirees, who are particularly sympathetic to this GOP Administration as it struggles to restore America's strength. We should not be bashful about tooting our horn on this subject, if only in the South.

G. THE NEED FOR MORE STUDY

Like stock market analysts and weather forecasters, politicians tend to exaggerate their individual powers of clairvoyance and intuition. The truth is that nobody knows the future.